

Let's Play, Gentlemen

Not exactly the real thing, but Brian Lara International Cricket 2005 is by far the best of the lot available

“What is life but a game of cricket,” asks the opening screen of Brian Lara International Cricket (BLIC) 2005. You may agree with that, but unfortunately, this game is no substitute for the real thing.

To be fair to the Codemasters, the creators of this game, no cricket game has been able to emulate the true feeling of playing cricket, but BLIC 2005 comes the closest so far. The graphics are great, as is the gameplay, but the player details and commentary leave a lot to be desired.

Match Time

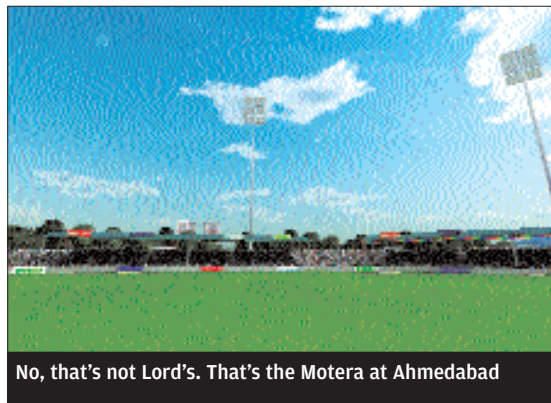
Before you can actually start playing a match, you have options to choose from... lots of options. Choose between a Challenge Match (England v Australia, 1887), World Series (multi team ODI Series), World Tour (Test and ODI series) and World Cup. We decided to pit India against Australia in a four-match Test series and six-match ODI series. Incidentally, six is the maximum number of ODIs you can choose in this mode.

That done, another options box popped up asking about the level of matches. Your choices are ‘Village’, ‘County’ or ‘Test’, with ‘Village’ being the easiest and ‘Test’ the toughest. In this box itself, you can also define the conditions for the match (Good, Warm, Humid, Cloudy), pitch (Hard, Damp, Dry, Crumbling) and the condition and make of the ball (Kookaburra, Dukes and Club).

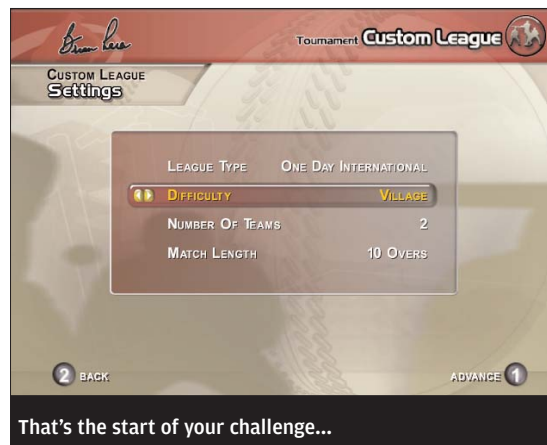
The next choice lets you pick your playing 11. All Test-playing nations are included in the game, and there are 16 players in each squad. The names of the players have been garbled—perhaps due to licensing issues. So Glenn McGrath is G MacGirth, Shane Warne is S Worde and so on! You can, of course, edit these names to put in the actual ones, but it’s a cumbersome task. Finally, it was time to play.

Gameplay

The match starts off with the toss, and an unidentified match referee accompanies the two captains to the pitch. Ricky Ponting called wrong, much to his chagrin, and India chose to bat.



No, that's not Lord's. That's the Motera at Ahmedabad



That's the start of your challenge...



All along, the commentators (David Gower and Ian Botham were voices we recognised) are apprising you of the conditions and how “they are happy to be in the commentary box”.

The Match

J Guiseppe (Jason Gillespie) was the first to mark his run-up. Among all the players, his was the face that had the maximum resemblance to a real player. As he runs up to bowl, we are scurrying to find the controls. By default, [W], [S], [A] and [D] are the controls during the game, and are also used to manoeuvre back and forth between screens when setting up the game.

There are three vertical bars on the bottom left that tell us about the bowler’s confidence level, the batsman’s confidence level and the timing of a shot.

Confidence levels for bowlers and batsmen change throughout the over, depending on how many dot balls are bowled, or how many times the bowler beats the batsman. Similarly, for the batsman, they rise with every run scored or every boundary hit. Normally, as one rises, the other falls.

Gillespie lets the first one rip outside the off